

CHAPTER

2

The Battle of Amritsar and Shaheeds Satwant and Beant Singh

The army went into Darbar Sahib not to eliminate a political figure or a political movement but to suppress the culture of a people, to attack their heart, to strike a blow at their spirit and self-confidence. The second crime, the penetration into the heart of many rural homes by non-family members in search of the young and fervent, gave rise to the early forms of resistance in the rural areas. The third crime, the systematic and planned attack on the Sikh settlements in...Delhi in which neighbourhoods were surrounded and their Sikh inhabitants set alight and burnt alive, was a massacre in the true sense of the term.

— Joyce J M Pettigrew, *The Sikhs of the Punjab*

As war was to break out between the Khalsa and the British-Indian forces in 1846, after the death of Ranjit Singh, the poet Shah Mohammad (1780-1862) penned the *Jangnama* ("Book of War") and saw the upcoming battle between Punjab and Hindustan in cosmic terms. He wrote the immortal words:

*Jang Hind Punjab da hon laga; Dhovay pathshahi
fauja bharian ne Aj hove sarkar te mul pave; Jihrian
khalse ne tega marian ne*

[Now starts the war between Hind and Punjab; both
sovereign armies are large. If today the ruler was still
alive, he would have valued the valour of the sword-
wielding Khalsa.]

The Battle (Jang) between Hind (India) and Punjab has taken many forms. The Battle of Amritsar (Operation Blue Star to the Indian Army) in 1984 was the latest manifestation of the contestation of sovereignty. Would the Akal Takht (Timeless Throne) continue to defy the Delhi Takht (Imperial Throne of Delhi)?

The Battle of Amritsar pitted an overwhelming array of Indian Army firepower against a band of armed Sikhs under Sant Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale and General Shabeg Singh. The former commanded battalions of commandos, tanks, helicopters, and artillery that had rehearsed the operation for over a year. The latter consisted of a group of young Sikhs who, according to eyewitness Norman Kreisman, possessed mostly antiquated WWII-era rifles, and home-made pistols that were often dangerous to the wielders. In addition to the main attack in Amritsar, over 38 other Gurdwaras throughout Punjab were also invaded, with heavy damage and killings in Patiala's Gurdwara Dukhniwaran Sahib, Muktsar, Nawanshahr, Tarn Taran, and others. This fact undermines the justification that the attack was carried out merely to apprehend Sant Bhindranwale; instead, it seemed more to have been a spectacle of force.

Commentators emphasize the punitive nature of the Indian operation. Joyce Pettigrew states that it was a form of punishment for Sikhs, meant to "suppress the culture, and political will, of a people" (Pettigrew, 8). Ram Narayan Kumar states that the attack was "calculated to scathe the Sikh psyche" (Kumar, *The Sikh Struggle*, 263). Indeed, the timing of the operation seems to support these allegations. Although Darbar Sahib had been picketed by Indian troops for years, and the attack had been rehearsed for at least

a year, the Indian Government launched its attack on the day of celebration of the shaheedi (martyrdom) of Guru Arjan, the Guru that constructed Harmandir Sahib. This was a day when Darbar Sahib would have been particularly full of pilgrims. Defenses of this abominable timing have been articulated, claiming that the operation was a time-sensitive, last-resort measure. Lt. General S. K. Sinha, the man originally selected to lead the operation, however, rebuked this claim, arguing that the resort to force was not a final option, and that he would have commanded a much different operation. He wrote:

It should have been ensured that we took due cognizance of the psychological aspect and not only acted correctly but should have seen to be acting correctly. I wish the operation had been conducted on the lines of what I had laid down, when I was the Army Commander in the west. That may have prevented a sense of hurt and alienation amongst the Sikhs. After Operation Bluestar, I received a number of letters from my Sikh friends saying that if I had been the Chief, Operation Bluestar would not have taken place. All I can say is that if I had been in the Army, I would have conducted this operation in an entirely different manner (Sinha, 392).

The operation assumed a particularly conspiratorial nature through its secrecy. Even high-ranking Sikh government officials, like President Zail Singh, were kept in the dark about it. Ram Naran Kumar writes, "President Zail Singh, himself the Supreme Commander of the Defense Forces, was kept deliberately ignorant of the impending assault by the Prime Minister who met him on May 30 to discuss with him a "new formula for negotiated settlement of the Punjab tangle." The President did not know what was happening even on June 4 when the assault had already been launched. On that day he was assuring a Sikh delegation visiting him that the army would not go into the temple" (Kumar, *The Sikh Struggle*, 264).

Zail Singh was further duped by the government when he inquired about the warnings given to pilgrims:

“I pointed out to her [Gandhi] that military action was taken on a day when the Temple complex was full of pilgrims – men, women and children – assembled to observe the martyrdom of Guru Arjan Dev...I told her that if notice had been given to these pilgrims over radio and television and loudspeakers, a majority of them would have come out...I had asked the government whether they had issued a warning on the loudspeakers to the people...to which they replied in the affirmative. Later, I came to know that no such warning had been issued and the operation had been suddenly launched” (Singh, *Memoirs of Giani Zail Singh*).

Despite all this, perhaps the most lasting legacy of the Battle of Amritsar in the psyche of many Sikhs was the tenacious defense of Darbar Sahib that Sant Jarnail Singh and the small army of Singhs and Kaurs undertook. This resistance in the face of all odds served as the inspiration for lore and further resistance among Sikhs for years thereafter; the number of poems, ballads, songs, and writings dedicated to this act testifies to the power of such an example. Thousands of Sikhs thereafter harkened back to the spirited Battle of Amritsar, and have placed Sant Jarnail Singh in the vaunted company of guardians of the sacred space. Sant Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale's name now occupies a lofty space alongside such heroes as Sukha Singh and Mehtab Singh, as well as those heads of Damdami Taksaal that came before Sant Jarnail Singh, including Baba Deep Singh and Baba Gurbaksh Singh. The courage required to stand up against an overwhelming force provided an ambitious standard by which young Sikhs measured themselves for years thereafter. Many fighters in the early stages of the insurgency thereafter cited Sant Bhindranwale's example as an inspiration (See the 1984-1994 chapter). In an age where Sikhs could not rely on any of their so-called leaders to take a stand on their behalf if it jeopardized their political careers, Shaheed

Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale and his followers offered their heads in defense of their Qaum (nation).

All-India Sikh Students Federation

One of the most important organizations that allied itself with Sant Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale was that of the All-India Sikh Students Federation (AISSF). The predecessors to the AISSF were the *Bhujangi Sabhas* and *Sikh Youngmens' Association* that formed in connection with the growing Singh Sabha movement in their desire to spread education and greater engagement with Sikh values and traditions. The AISSF was originally founded before the partition of Punjab. It was on September 13, 1944 that 13 Sikhs came together to start a new organization.

A number of Sikh luminaries were members of the AISSF and their popular Gurmat camps were influential in spreading Sikh values and principles. A number of Sikh politicians and scholars, including Surjit Singh Barnala, Ajit Singh Bains, Jaswant Singh Neki, Manmohan Singh, Harbans Lal, and Principal Satbir Singh were members and leaders within the AISSF.

However, the AISSF's greatest ascent to prominence came in the late 1970s. It was during this time that Bhai Amrik Singh, the son of Sant Kartar Singh Bhindranwale of the Damdami Taksaal, was elected president of the Beas division of the AISSF. Amrik Singh completed his masters in Punjabi at Khalsa College Amritsar, and embarked upon his PhD studies. Joyce Pettigrew, who met Sant Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale and Bhai Amrik Singh, in mid-December 1983 writes, "Amrik Singh was very kind and possibly the more saintly of the two, but with less charismatic appeal" (*South Asia Research*, p 102-123). During this period in the late 1970s, he subsequently became the President of the AISSF. Bibi Upkar Kaur from Karnal (now in Haryana) became the President of the Women's Wing of the AISSF. It was under their leadership and activism that the AISSF, which had been moribund by the late 1970s, was revitalized. Nearly every college in Punjab had an associate chapter and women's wing. Although the AISSF did not

have a defined membership, some projections estimated that the organization claimed nearly 100,000 active members.

Increasing the appeal and outreach of the Sikh message to collegiate students across India, Bhai Amrik Singh and Bibi Upkar Kaur inspired many members that would take key roles in the organization. Some of the most notable include Atinderpal Singh, a student from Bhopal, who would become Senior Deputy President of the AISSF outside of Punjab, and in 1989 be elected as Member of Parliament from Patiala. Harpal Singh, who would later be extradited from the United States to India in 2006, was another important activist. Daljit Singh Bittoo was another leader of the AISSF and would later wage a successful campaign against government leaders and officials. Kulbir Singh Barapind, another notable fighter, was also extradited from the United States in 2006, and in 2012 won an SGPC election.

In June 1984, it would be Presidents Bhai Amrik Singh and Bibi Upkar Kaur that would join Sant Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale in defense of the oncoming assault by the Indian Army. Both Bhai Amrik Singh and Bibi Upkar Kaur gave their lives in protection of Darbar Sahib and are thus honored by Sikhs, especially students, for their leadership, inspiration, fortitude, and sacrifice.

In subsequent militant activities following the Battle of Amritsar, members of the AISSF, both men and women, were active participants and provided a fertile recruiting ground for the intellectual and combat arms of the Sikh uprising.

The Generals of the Battle of Amritsar

Before the battle, Lt. General S. K. Sinha of the Indian Army had been selected to lead the operation. He declined the offer, citing sacrilege and unnecessary violence. He was terminated as a result. He was replaced by Arun Vaidya, who was assisted by Lt. General K. Sundarji, and General Kuldip Brar. Recent reports have indicated that the government of the United Kingdom, under Margaret Thatcher, had sent military advisors to train and direct the Indian troops involved in the assault.

Former Major General Shabeg Singh trained the troops that Sant Jarnail Singh led into battle. Shabeg Singh traced his lineage back to Mehtab Singh, who had ended the life of Massa Ranghar, the imperialist occupier of Harmandir Sahib in 1740. He was said to be descended from Rattan Singh Bhangoo, author of the famed historical text, *Guru Panth Parkash*. Known for his sharp wit, sense of duty (he commanded troops with distinction the day he learned of his father's death), and intuitive grasp of warfare, he became a popular and accomplished general.

Shabeg Singh began his military career in 1940, joining the British Indian Army in World War II to fight the Japanese. His regiment fought until the end of the war in that theater, in such jungle environments as Burma that instructed him in the basics of guerrilla warfare. Later, he was deployed to Kashmir against the Pakistani Army, and was promoted throughout the ranks in a number of conflicts where he served with distinction.

Shabeg Singh's greatest accolades came from his participation in the 1971 war against Pakistan. He was placed in charge of the training of the guerrilla "Mukhti Bahini" Bengali outfits. His clandestine guerrilla war set the stage for Indian military intervention in modern Bangladesh, and helped secure an easy victory for General Jagjit Singh Arora.

During the Emergency, Shabeg Singh was ordered to arrest political dissidents that had organized protests against Indira Gandhi. Acting on his conscience and commitment to democracy, Shabeg Singh refused to imprison the activists. The Indian government then opted to punish this refusal, and prosecuted him on trumped-up charges that were later proven to be false, according to Inderjeet Singh Jaijee, a well-known human rights activist in Punjab and the maternal uncle of Captain Amrinder Singh of Patiala. The army similarly attempted to punish him for receiving commemorative plaques for his victories, which were routinely given to successful commanders. A compliant Indian media would try to characterize Shabeg Singh as a disgruntled traitor who was terminated for corruption, but such allegations are unsupported by facts. Shabeg Singh was dismissed from the Army in 1976, just a day before his retirement.

Around 1980, Shabeg Singh became involved in the campaign for political rights in Punjab. Joining a growing list of ex-servicemen, he began fighting against illegal quotas that limited the number of Sikhs in the military, and against the diversion of Punjab's river waters to Haryana, Delhi, and Rajasthan. He and other veterans took offense to the characterization of Sikhs as terrorists. During the course of the protests, he was arrested a number of times. His brother was murdered, with many believing it was on the orders of Indian government officials. Despite these attacks, his commitment to stand up against the government gained the admiration of many other activists.

After witnessing the offenses heaped upon Sikhs during the Asian Games of 1982, Shabeg Singh was outraged by the injustice. He decided to escalate his involvement in the Dharam Yudh Morcha. As his faith in the opportunist Akali party dwindled, he saw in Sant Jarnail Singh a rare leader of integrity and commitment. To Shabeg Singh, Sant Jarnail Singh was the only one on the political scene whose interest was to improve the state of the Sikh Qaum. The Akalis made lofty promises while out of power, only to renege, collude, and collaborate with the Indian government for their personal gains. Shabeg Singh recruited other ex-servicemen to the cause. When Sant Jarnail Singh requested his assistance at Darbar Sahib in 1984, Shabeg Singh answered the call and offered his head. He provided his expertise in guerrilla warfare to the men and women assembled there. His emphasis on shock tactics demoralized the Indian shock troops, and resulted in inordinately high casualties for the Indian Army.

The Battle of Amritsar, a Timeline

June 1, 1984:

The Indian Army began to take up positions around Darbar Sahib, surrounding it completely. They conducted reconnaissance on the compound by firing on the complex while pilgrims were inside, hoping to have the Sikhs retaliate and reveal their positions. They specifically targeted the Guru Ram Das Langar, killing a number of

Sikhs. Bhindranwale's men held firm to their positions and did not return fire to any major extent (Kumar, 264).

June 2:

The Indian Army carried out operations throughout Punjab. Hundreds of thousands (some estimates put the number at nearly 300,000) of troops flooded the state, cutting off transit into and out of Punjab. Troops sealed every border and imposed a media blackout by arresting or expelling foreign journalists. The lone foreign correspondent remaining in Amritsar was Brahma Chellaney of the Associated Press, who eluded authorizes, and whose reports alerted the world to the abusive excesses that the Indian Army took during the assault. The Indian government even ordered electrical outages in key cities, including Amritsar, Ludhiana, Jalandhar, Patiala, and other important locales to reduce chances for any communication.

June 3:

The Indian government imposed a strict curfew in Punjab, confining Sikhs to their homes. Troops were concentrated most heavily in areas where Sikhs formed the majority of residents. By this point, Punjab was essentially cut off from the rest of the world. Worshippers were still being allowed in, but not out. They were to be trapped by the army. Intense small-arms and artillery firing resumed without warning, but still, most of Bhindranwale's men refused to betray their positions. According to the report filed by Citizens for Democracy, "they had been given no inkling or warning either of the sudden curfew or of the imminent Army attack. It was to be a black-hole tragedy, not out of forgetfulness but out of deliberate planning and design."

June 4:

The Indian Army's advance commenced, and continued the intense shelling of the perimeter of Darbar Sahib. The historic Ramgharia

Bungas (towers) were destroyed by the shelling, and a number of innocents both inside and outside of Darbar Sahib were killed by the hail of shells. Certain Sikh members of the military in fact began refusing to obey orders. Attempting to play the “caste card,” the Sikh Light Infantry unit was mobilized, as General Brar believed that their participation would be able to be used as propaganda for the “secular” nature of the attack. The Sikh Light Infantry was largely composed of Sikhs of Mazhabi origin, and the military calculated that they would be willing to lead the assault. In fact, more than fifty troops of the Sikh Light Infantry refused to participate. The Indian Army with the rest of its contingents now made all of its preparations for its first major assault and both sides braced for combat. The fourth largest army in the world was about to begin its attack on Darbar Sahib and some eighty Sikh men and women were going to give their lives to defend it.

June 5:

By the morning, this intermittent firing and shelling had died down with little response from the Sikh defenders. The generals felt that “the militants...had been sufficiently demoralized for the specially trained commandos to capture them.” (Kumar, 264). At 7 A.M., the first wave of nearly 100 commandos entered Darbar Sahib and received a furious response from the Sikhs. Trained by Shabeg Singh, these men began to harangue the army from every angle, confusing the Indian soldiers. They had opened gaps in walls that they fired from, fortified positions throughout Darbar Sahib, and traveled back and forth in tunnels that ran underneath the ground, opening up manholes to lob grenades and lay down withering machine gun fire. Over half of this group of commandos was destroyed (Kumar, 264).

The discipline that the defenders demonstrated shocked the Indian commanders. They ordered a new group into Darbar Sahib. This time, they sent a large group of para-trooper commandos through the front entrance, and also launched simultaneous attacks from the west and southeast. This effort to overwhelm and intimidate the Sikhs failed, as the Singhs and Kaurs held firm in their

positions and continued to hold steady despite the overwhelming firepower. They pinned the troops down at the entrances and drove this group back in the same way that they did with the first assault. The army would need to reformulate its attack plan to capture the entrenched areas where the Sikhs were firing out of, and clear all pathways of fire.

This effort, according to Ram Narayan Kumar, was no easier than the first two failed attacks. “Hundreds of soldiers died” while attempting to dislodge the valiant Sikhs (Kumar, 264). The army managed to capture these areas, but the Singhs and Kaurs remained undaunted. The army’s assault on the Akal Takht itself met with disaster. As the commandos attempted to cross open spaces, the Sikhs continued the fight with guerrilla-style tactics, and trapped them. Out of desperation, the Indian Army attempted to use gas and chemical weapons, but to no avail. The wind blew the gas away, which wound up causing more Indian troops to die (Kumar, 264). Shabeg Singh had anticipated that the commandos would be crawling along the parkarma (walkways), and trained his machine gunners to aim no higher than a foot off the ground. This resulted in many leg injuries to the invading troops.

After the third wave of attackers was beaten back, a fourth group was ordered into Darbar Sahib. The Sikhs maintained their discipline, even as Vijayanta tanks entered the compound.

June 6:

The operation continued to meet with disaster. By the evening, “the soldiers were demoralized and in a mutinous mood.” The commanders requested to use tanks and artillery on the Akal Takht itself, and were granted permission. The marble of the parkarma crumbled underneath the tank treads. The government claims that Sikhs used a rocket propelled grenade to stop the first tank. This assertion is questionable, however. Norman Kreisman, an eyewitness to the events that unfolded in the Darbar Sahib between 1982 and 1984, stated that the Sikhs assembled there did not have access to such weapons. Instead, Sikhs hold that Bibi

Pritam Kaur, outraged by the destruction of Akal Takht, gathered her family and instructed them to strap bombs to themselves. This included her two young daughters. They destroyed the first tank into the complex, but this did not prevent the remaining tanks from obliterating the edifice of Akal Takht.

June 7:

More tanks rolled in, and the shelling intensified. The Indian Army began to take hold of the complex. The remaining fighters persisted in their resistance sporadically, and a group of four Sikhs barricaded themselves in a bunker and continued to fight for days. That night, Sant Jarnail Singh was killed. According to Joyce Pettigrew, a government doctor confirmed his capture, and at least one journalist had reported seeing a picture of him in army custody with a small wound to the temple (Pettigrew, 35). He was tortured to death, according to these eyewitnesses. Shabeg Singh was also said to have been captured and tortured to death, with his scalp removed (Pettigrew, 35).

On this day, with the battle already winding down, and Indian Army in full control of the complex, the Indian soldiers began their rampage. Unfortunately, the end to the main battle did not stop the violence. Ram Narayan Kumar states that “the army, which had suffered a heavy toll in three days of battle, went berserk and killed every Sikh to be found in the temple complex. They were hauled out of rooms, brought to the corridors in the circumference of the Temple, and with hands tied to their back were shot in cold blood. Among the victims were many old men, women and children.” (Kumar, 264)

The Indian Army then proceeded to burn the Sikh Reference Library to the ground. Thousands of priceless artifacts, historical documents, and collections of scripture were lost. Eyewitnesses, interviewed by Mark Tully and Satish Jacob, raised serious doubts about the Indian Army’s version of the events, stating that “any army, which wants to destroy a nation destroys its culture. That is why the Indian army burnt the library.” A Central Bureau of Intelligence officer reported that the army was scouring the library for a letter,

purportedly written to Sant Bhindranwale by Indira Gandhi. When the investigation failed to recover the letter, they burned the library down (Walia). However, all was not lost in the library blaze. In fact, gunny sacks of historical artifacts were looted by the Indian Army. Even as late as 2003, the Indian Government confirmed that they still are holding most of this invaluable material except the 117 historical items that they destroyed for being “seditious,” including Hukamnamas by Guru Gobind Singh (Walia).

The army celebrated this victory with thousands of quarts of alcohol, which they drank inside Darbar Sahib.

The soldiers freely drank and smoked inside the complex. They certainly had plenty to drink, a notification of the Government of Punjab’s Department of Excise and Taxation allowed for the provision of 700,000 quart bottles of rum, 30,000 quart bottles of whiskey, 60,000 quart bottles of brandy and 160,000 bottles of beer all for the “consumption by the Armed Forces Personnel deployed in Operation Blue Star.” (Tully and Jacob)

June 10:

The battle ended as a final group of four armed Sikhs met their end. As news of the battle spread across Punjab, thousands of Sikhs, as if reacting to some blind impulse, began marching on Amritsar in spite of the shoot-on-sight curfews imposed by the army. The government responded by tightening restrictions on travel, and using its coercive power against these outraged Sikhs. Helicopters patrolled the highways and mowed down civilians. Gurkha soldiers, empowered with orders to shoot any on the streets after hours, massacred many. Still, thousands upon thousands of Sikhs gathered whatever they could in the way of weaponry and attempted to wrest Amritsar back from the army. Tellingly, over 5,000 Sikh soldiers revolted, breaking out of their barracks (which they had been locked in) and marching on the Indian Army (Kumar, 269). The uprising was largely uncoordinated, and many soldiers perished after being surrounded by hostile troops

(Pettigrew, 36). Many of those that survived went underground and joined the resistance. They are still remembered today in the Sikh community as the “Dharmi Faujis” (Righteous Military Men), who gave up their livelihoods, careers, and income in order to stand with their Sikh nation.

Brahma Chellaney, the only journalist to avoid arrest and expulsion from Punjab in the leadup to the battle, reported seeing truckloads of bodies being removed from Darbar Sahib, while it was closed to the public. He contacted physicians that were forced to conduct ad hoc postmortems, and confirmed that many Sikhs had been bound before being shot in the head (Kumar, 265). The government cremated the bodies en masse and offered to let cleanup crews keep whatever they found on bodies. No remains were returned to families (Pettigrew, 36).

In all, the battle proved to be costly for the invading forces. The stubborn resistance exacted a heavy toll on the invading troops. While the assault of Darbar Sahib proved to be a crushing emotional blow for many, other Sikhs expressed admiration of the courage and effectiveness of the men and women that had offered their heads in this first battle. Their example would be the stuff legends are made of. Sant Jarnail Singh and his Singhs and Kaurs were hailed by Sikhs throughout the world, lauded by dhadhi jathas and other artists, and became heroes for generations.

In addition to the destruction of Darbar Sahib, the Indian Government attacked 38 other Gurdwaras simultaneously. Local Sikhs resisted and fought against these Indian Army assaults. Large numbers of Sikhs were killed in Gurdwaras in Patiala, Moga, Muktsar, and others. The attack on all these Gurdwaras places large doubt on the justification that the Indian Government was only attempting to dislodge Sant Jarnail Singh and his men. In fact, such a coordinated attack planned a year in advance seems to substantiate the claim by Sant Jarnail Singh that the Indian Government was always planning to attack Darbar Sahib and the Sikhs. Far from an occupier, Sant Jarnail Singh was the defender against the planned attack. Sant Jarnail Singh, Bhai Amrik Singh, Bibi Upkar Kaur, Bibi Paramjit Kaur, Bhai Shabeg Singh, and a few dozen more had withstood the fierce attack of the fourth largest army in the world for days. The uprising

in the Punjab countryside was only quelled by helicopters as the powerful Army arsenal unleashed against the civilian population.

The Battle of Amritsar only began to hint at the scope of violence and terror that would be unleashed against the Sikhs. The Punjabi countryside was alight with both grief and a subversive pride that filled its denizens with resolve. This expressed itself in a commitment to undertake resistance against the State, even as hundreds of thousands of soldiers poured across the borders into Punjab. Ram Narayan Kumar wrote that “the assault on the Temple succeeded in completely estranging the Sikhs from the State which had caused it. Even those Sikhs who had hitherto been staunch supporters of the government reacted with shock and anger” (Kumar, 266). Khushwant Singh, a self-proclaimed agnostic “renegade” who opposed Bhindranwale, himself lamented the “savage display of power, calculated to humiliate the Sikh community.” He returned government awards and declared that he felt that he did not live in a secular state.

The wanton violence inflicted by the Indian army far exceeded even the most speculative claims made about Sant Jarnail Singh. A commentator noted that “the army had taken more than four thousand lives, the majority of whom were innocent pilgrims or employees of the SGPC. By all available accounts the Sikh militants killed during the operation did not exceed two hundred. Roughly seven hundred men and officers of the Indian army had to die.” According to this same observer, armed Sikhs were alleged to have killed 200 people in the entire leadup to the operation by the government (Kumar, 265).

The Sacrifices of Satwant and Beant Singh

Satwant Singh, selected to serve as Indira Gandhi’s bodyguard for his sharpshooting skills, was aghast when he traveled to witness the carnage that had enveloped Darbar Sahib. He, along with his companion on the crack squad, Beant Singh, traveled to Amritsar after hearing triumphant government broadcasts that touted its success during the Battle of Amritsar. The ruins of the Akal Takht, and the pervasive sense of grief and loss that enveloped Darbar

Sahib, gripped the two soldiers. They had also heard of the great sacrifice undertaken by the men and women there, and were inspired by the examples of Sant Jarnail Singh and the Singhs and Kaurs. Beant Singh consulted his uncle, Kehar Singh, who was reputed to have insights into Sikh philosophy, and occupied a position of influence in the young soldier's life. After exchanging words with Kehar Singh, Satwant and Beant Singh resolved to seek justice for the destruction wrought by Delhi. Inspired by the loving tradition of Sikhs that had risked life and limb to protect the sanctity of Darbar Sahib, they took the *khanda di pahul* and became Singhs. Drinking from the Cup of Love (piram piala), they took their place alongside Sukha Singh, Mehtab Singh, Baba Deep Singh Ji, and Sant Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale. The two soldiers vowed to eliminate the tyrannical rule of Indira Gandhi as symbol of Delhi Takht and the Indian State. The pair prepared themselves to "play the Game of Love" and make the ultimate sacrifice for the Panth.

On the morning of October 31st, Indira Gandhi was approaching her residence for an interview with an Irish television program. Satwant Singh, who was normally assigned a different post, feigned a stomach illness to secure a more strategic position. As Gandhi passed by, Beant Singh fired three rounds with his revolver. Satwant Singh then drew his automatic weapon and shot her 30 times. In the ensuing chaos that followed, the two men resolutely dropped their weapons and waited to be apprehended. In fact, some of Indira Gandhi's attendants recalled that the men dropped their weapons and declared to their colleagues, "We have done what we needed to, now you can do what you have to." Beant Singh was subsequently killed in custody on site, and Satwant Singh was repeatedly tortured. As a result, Kehar Singh was also apprehended and sentenced to death alongside Satwant Singh.

While he was in custody, Satwant Singh's fiancée, Surinder Kaur, organized an Anand Karaj (wedding) ceremony, where she wed him *in absentia* so that she would be able to visit him in prison. His resolute composure in the face of death awed his family and admirers alike. When asked to give a final statement in court, Satwant Singh called for an end to communal violence, and

expressed his joyous contentment with his fate. On January 6th, 1989, Satwant Singh and Kehar Singh were hanged, and joined an illustrious tradition of Shaheeds (martyrs) who died in the defense of the Sikh Qaum.

Satwant Singh's call for communal harmony, however, went unheeded by most of India. A frenzied press linked the assassination of Gandhi to the entire corpus of the Sikh community, and stoked a seething population. The Congress Party and the BJP had stumbled upon a rare point of confluence, as their leadership both began organizing their followers and mobilizing their resources to carry out a truly gruesome chapter of Indian history.